

■ By Manisha Mohite in Bonn

The Euro-centric world of chess would not admit it, but Viswanathan Anand has had to win the title of world champion not once but three times, his third title triumph in Bonn over Russian Vladimir Kramnik, being the sweetest and many believe the longest arriving.

Anand is the only man in the 122-year-old history of the world championship to win the world title in all three formats and thus ending all arguments about his claim to be the greatest player in the world today. In 2000 he won the title through a knock-out event held in India and Iran, and in the 2007 World Championship in Mexico City he fought off the world's top seven players in a double round-robin and was still denied his due by sceptics.

Even though Mexico City was touted as the first unified World Championship after the Gary Kasparov breakaway from the International Chess Federation in 1993, once again Anand found that the goal posts had been shifted. A few months before Bonn, Kramnik even declared, "The tournament in Mexico was from my point of view a huge compromise.... I still believe that the real chess championship is actually a match between the best players, not a tournament." After Bonn, a rout by world championship standards, Anand said the triumph was all the sweeter as it had come, "against one of the best match-players of all time." Touché.

Whether Kramnik's taunt was his way of getting his pre-match psychological punch early or talking up his chances for the benefit of his home audience and sponsors, it is immaterial. Bonn was always going to be about more than just chess: it had all the ingredients of a classic final between two contrasting players and of course each man's pride and sense of redemption.

The world of chess had been clamouring for a one-on-one between Anand, 38, whose exciting, racy style of play made him a favourite with audiences and the 33-year-old Kramnik, more conventional and the darling of the purists. Anand's is a home-made talent which has flourished despite formidable odds, while Kramnik is a product of Russia's systematic school of chess. Both men had dominated the

THE BONN SUPREMACY

With three decisive wins over Kramnik, Anand stamps his authority forcefully and may succeed in silencing his critics



Anand has won titles in all formats of the game, right from blitz to rapid forms as well as the elite levels

rankings and their events, featuring in the world's top three for almost 15 years running. In the 1990s, the shadow of Kasparov, the world's highest-rated player ever loomed over them both but the millennium gave both men the chance to step into the sun.

Bonn's Art and Exhibition Hall was turned into a fitting arena for these gladiators of the mind. Four hundred spectators filed in every day, ranging from those who paid 35 Euros for a single game ticket (which sometimes involved squatting on the stairs to watch) and 280 Euros for an exclusive one-day ticket. They were separated from the

only illuminated spot in the room—the competition table—by a net that blocked out the ambient noise from the crowd. There were chess geeks from Germany and NRIs from Europe, USA and even Australia. Among the audience were researchers in artificial intelligence and genetics, drawn to the event to dig deeper into specific aspects of the contest. A commentary hall next door accommodated the spillover fans with an audience following the match 'live' with grandmasters providing running commentary in German. The excited buzz of chess talk was unmistakable, and all the buzz re-